

Mohenjo-Daro

One of the earliest cities in the world and a major center of the ancient Indus Valley civilization



Located in the middle of the floodplain of the Indus Valley in present-day Sindh, Pakistan, Mohenjo-Daro dates back to the 3rd millennium BCE. It flourished at much the same time as the civilizations of ancient Egypt, Mesopotamia, Minoan Crete, and Norte Chico. The remains of the city are evidence of a system of urban planning: the unbaked brick buildings are laid out to a strict grid pattern, with a citadel on a promontory above the lower residential area.

The major structures of the city are within the citadel and include a large residential

structure, assembly halls, and a central marketplace. Of particular interest are the public baths and wells, which were serviced by a sophisticated irrigation and drainage system. The central areas were heavily fortified, and the city was also protected by fortifications and guard towers to the south and west.



◀ SOPHISTICATED ARTIFACTS

This pottery container is just one of several artifacts excavated at Mohenjo-Daro that provide evidence of a highly developed civilization with a flourishing culture.

Ziggurat of Ur

A distinctive pyramidlike structure dominating the ruins of the ancient city of Ur



Ziggurats are a form of temple pyramids peculiar to the ancient civilizations of what is now Iraq and Iran. Unlike Egyptian pyramids, they are tiered structures with flights of steps between the different levels. One of the largest and best-preserved of these is at the site of the Neo-Sumerian city of Ur, near Nasiriyah in present-day Iraq, built in the 21st century BCE.

Structures of worship

The Ziggurat of Ur was constructed as a temple to the Moon god Nanna. Its original height is estimated to have been 70–100ft (21–31m), making the shrine at its top a highly visible landmark.

By the 6th century BCE, however, its mud-brick structure had largely crumbled, and it was restored by the Neo-Babylonian King Nabonidus using a protective outer layer of baked bricks set in bitumen. It was further restored in the 20th century, with the addition of a reconstruction of the facade and main staircase, which suffered damage during the 1991 Gulf War.

▽ COLOSSAL TEMPLE

This image shows the restored facade of the ziggurat, with its main stairway leading up to the level on which the shrine of the Moon god Nanna would have stood.

